

# Grade 8

## B.E.S.T. Writing

### Sample Test Materials

The purpose of these sample test materials is to orient teachers and students to the appearance of passages and prompts on paper-based accommodated B.E.S.T. Writing tests. Each spring, students in grades 4–10 are administered one text-based writing prompt for the B.E.S.T. Writing test. Students will respond to either an expository prompt or to an argumentative prompt. An example of a text-based writing prompt for each grade is available for practice. To familiarize students with the response formats, teachers may encourage students to practice with each type of prompt within a grade band.

The following B.E.S.T. Writing sample test materials are available on the Florida Statewide Assessments Portal as shown below:

#### **Elementary Grade Band**

Grade 4 - Expository

Grade 5 - Argumentative

#### **Middle Grade Band**

Grade 6 - Expository

Grade 7 - Argumentative

Grade 8 - Expository

#### **High School Grade Band**

Grade 9 - Argumentative

Grade 10 - Expository

The sample test materials are not intended to guide classroom instruction.

# Writing Prompt

Studies show that clothing affects people's behavior.

Write an expository essay about how people's thoughts and actions are influenced by what they wear.

Your expository essay must be based on this prompt and topic, and it must incorporate ideas and information found in the sources provided.

Use your best writing to complete an essay that

- is focused on your central idea;
- combines evidence from multiple sources with your own elaboration to develop your ideas;
- is organized and includes transitions within and among ideas;
- provides citations for quoted material and source ideas; and
- demonstrates correct use of grammar and language appropriate to the task.

Write your multiparagraph essay to an academic audience in the space provided.

Read the “Dress for Success?” sources.

### Dress for Success?

## Source 1: You are what you DRESS: Clothing has a significant effect on self-esteem and confidence, claims expert

by Jonathan O’Callaghan

- 1       What’s the secret to being confident? . . .
- 2       [A]ccording to one researcher, the answer may in fact lie in what we’re wearing.
- 3       Professor Karen Pine from the University of Hertfordshire said that specific clothing—including even superhero T-shirts—can make people more confident in all sorts of situations.
- 4       The research is outlined in her new book *Mind What You Wear*.
- 5       In the book she claims clothing affects a person’s mental processes and perceptions.
- 6       And ultimately, what you wear could discern how confident you feel about yourself.
- 7       “We know our clothes affect other people’s impressions of us,” Professor Pine told the MailOnline.
- 8       “Now research shows what we wear affects us too.
- 9       “Putting on different clothes creates different thoughts and mental processes.
- 10      “My book aims to make people more aware of this, to understand how changing their clothes can change their mood and their thoughts.”
- 11      In the study, she gathered a group of students and asked some to wear a Superman T-shirt.
- 12      She wanted to know if heroic clothing would change how students thought.
- 13      Surprisingly, she found that not only did it make them more confident, but it also made them actually think they were physically stronger.

14        “When wearing a Superman T-shirt the students rated themselves as more likeable and superior to other students,” she explained in a release from the University of Hertfordshire.

15        “When asked to estimate how much they could physically lift, those in a Superman T-shirt thought they were stronger than students in a plain T-shirt, or in their own clothing.”

Excerpt from “You are what you DRESS: Clothing has a significant effect on self-esteem and confidence, claims expert” by Jonathan O’Callaghan. Copyright © 2018 by the Daily Mail. Reprinted by permission of the Daily Mail via Copyright Clearance Center.

## **Source 2: Lab coats help students see themselves as future scientists**

by Megan Ennes and M. Gail Jones

16        In order to encourage more of the nation’s young people to pursue careers in science, it pays to help them dress the part.

17        That is the key finding of a study we conducted recently to determine what kind of effect a simple article of clothing—in this case white lab coats—have on students’ confidence in their ability to do science. We also wanted to know if lab coats help students see themselves as scientists and aspire to science careers.

18        We are science education researchers interested in understanding how the symbols and tools of science can promote students’ interest in studying science.

19        This is an important topic because jobs in science, technology, engineering and math—or STEM jobs—are not only important for the economy, but are also growing faster and pay more than many other fields.

20        Although the number of jobs in STEM fields are increasing, the number of people choosing to major in those fields remains below what is needed to fill the positions.

### **The power of clothing**

21        In order to encourage more young people to choose to major in STEM fields and pursue STEM careers, we believe it is important to help them see themselves as someone who can be successful in those fields. One item often associated with scientists is the white lab coat.

22 Clothing can be a powerful tool for changing one’s self-image, as seen in previous studies of the effects of suits and lab coats on adults.

23 In an effort to help students see themselves as scientists and as individuals who can be successful in science, we conducted a study that put students in lab coats for science instruction. . . .

### **Same lessons, different attire**

24 For each teacher, students in one of the classes wore lab coats for at least 10 class periods over the course of two months. The other class did not wear lab coats. The teachers taught the same lessons to each class to minimize the differences between teachers. The participants were interviewed before and after the 10 lessons and also took a pre- and post-survey that explored many factors, such as their sense of self as a scientist, their confidence in their skills related to science, and whether they had career goals related to STEM fields.

25 For the 110 youth in the group who didn’t wear lab coats, there were no statistically significant changes in their responses from the pretest to post-test for any question on the written survey. However, for the students who wore the lab coats, there was a significant increase in their perceptions of whether others see them as scientists.

26 More specifically, of the 72 students who wore lab coats, 47 percent changed their responses on the post-survey to indicate they feel like others see them as someone who likes science.

27 Also, of the 42 lab coat-wearing students who had low levels of confidence in their science skills, 45 percent changed their responses on the post-test to positive responses. . . .

### **Positive effects**

28 To test for performance and competence in science, students were asked questions such as “I think I am good at science” and “I am good at using science tools like thermometers, rulers or magnifying glasses.” The youth who wore lab coats but had low levels of self-confidence had a significant increase in their responses to these questions. More specifically, 60 percent of the students changed their answer from disagree to agree.

29 To test for career aspirations, the students were asked questions such as “I would like to have a job that uses science.” For the students wearing the lab coats who had low confidence in their science skills, 50 percent changed their answers from disagree to agree.

### **A worthy investment**

- 30 The bottom line is that for youth that initially had low levels of confidence in their science skills, the lab coats had a significant improvement in their beliefs in their abilities, their levels of recognition and their science career aspirations.

Excerpt from "Lab coats help students see themselves as future scientists" by Megan Ennes and M. Gail Jones from *The Conversation*. Licensed under CC BY-ND 4.0.

### **Source 3: Workers are dressing more casually. Does that affect productivity?**

by Cindy Krischer Goodman

- 31 [A]s office dress codes become more relaxed, some employers worry that the work ethic will weaken. Will wearing polo shirts to the office discourage employees from staying past 6 p.m.? Will dressing in khakis instead of a power suit make a manager less likely to invite clients to lunch? Will wearing sandals lessen someone's motivation to negotiate a deal?
- 32 Business consultant Andrew Jensen, who has studied the correlation between office workwear and productivity, says that just as managers disagree on the issue of attire, there also has been a lack of consensus among researchers: "It comes down to office environment. In a more relaxed environment, casual dress works and doesn't have much impact. In a more traditional environment, casual dress does have an impact, especially when employees go too far."
- 33 Jensen of the Sozo Firm in Pennsylvania says that in some workplaces, bosses contend that the national trend toward business-casual wear can boost morale and camaraderie and even increase creativity by allowing workers to feel comfortable and happy. In others, supervisors say that business-casual can easily be abused and lead to sloppiness, laziness and a decrease in professionalism. "The dress code really needs to be customized depending who your customers are and how often you interact with them," Jensen says.
- 34 On a given day, what we wear to work can affect our focus, motivation and what we accomplish, says Mike Slepian, adjunct assistant professor at Columbia Business School and author of "The Cognitive Consequences of Formal Clothing." He says casual clothing makes workers think less abstractly and more concretely—useful for

completing tasks focusing on details such as writing code or planning a product launch. He says that with formal dress, workers feel more powerful and ready to tackle higher level abstract thinking. He says that when workers need to think creatively about the bigger picture, that's when dressing formally will increase productivity.

- 35 In offices that have Casual Fridays, some employees see their mood shift with the change in work attire. Georgi Pipkin, corporate manager of marketing at Baptist Health South Florida, dresses for the interactions planned for the day and finds that her outlook correlates with her clothing: "If I'm wearing jeans on a Friday, I have a more relaxed, less stressful day. If I'm wearing a dress, I might be meeting with a vendor and there's an expectation that I'm going to perform at a different level." . . .
- 36 Conservative businesses that have relaxed their dress code see the results. Dorothy Eisenberg, a partner in Miami's Gerson Preston, says the transition into business-casual at her firm has created a workplace culture that attracts young workers, the lifeblood of an accounting firm: "It shows that we are not stuffy, that we are complying with what the market is like, and that our people are more relaxed and happy." Eisenberg believes the positive atmosphere leads to happier clients, too: "When the morale is high, it affects productivity."
- 37 However, pushing the boundaries of business-casual too far can be problematic in any workplace. As a corporate trainer and Dallas-based business coach, Shontaye Hawkins works with companies across the country and suggests they provide employees photos of exactly what they consider business-casual. Dressing . . . too casually can adversely affect the employee and employer, she says: "When you wear flip-flops and shorts, you become less focused on work. It's like you can't wait to get off, and you're thinking about everything outside of the office versus work that needs to get done."

Excerpt from "Workers are dressing more casually. Does that affect productivity?" by Cindy Krischer Goodman. Copyright © 2016 by the Miami Herald. Reprinted by permission of the Miami Herald via Copyright Clearance Center.

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Lined writing area with 25 horizontal lines.

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This image shows a single page of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are approximately 20 lines visible. The paper has a thin black border around the edges.